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Love 2.0 Final Draft

Gravity, entropy, the forward motion of time, love - all hegemonic forces that society has defined to be omnipotent and unchanging. One of these, however, may not seem like the others; and the truth is that it is not. Unlike the others, the emotion of love is a man-made construct that has been glossed over by mankind for millennia, being perceived as both the villain that brings widespread disaster and the hero that removes it all. It seems to be an unstoppable force that cannot be controlled or summoned at will, only experienced. In an article excerpt of her 2013 novel "Love 2.0: How Our Supreme Emotion Affects Everything We Feel, Think, Do, and Become", Barbara Fredrickson challenges the long established notion of love as viewed by society, be it the yearning and desire for something, unconditional and exclusive relationships, or even lifelong commitments. Instead, she urges the reader to take a step back and view love from the perspective of his or her body - as a biological system. Fredrickson attempts to claim that many of the traits commonly misattributed to the emotion of love are actually just side effects of a myriad of internal processes within the body, activated upon positive interactions with others. Although Fredrickson backs up her points with valid research and reasoning, her new framework for love is oversimple and heavily romanticized, oftentimes sounding more like a sales pitch than a scholarly piece of work. Her "body perspective" of love fails to explain how the many divergent ideas of love relate to and reinforce one another, and instead uses new guises to reiterate ancient ideas that have been present in society for centuries.

Fredrickson often uses creative and intuitive word choice and writing style to convince the reader she has found something groundbreaking and new about love from the perspective of the body. Many times, Fredrickson describes a study carried out on a particular facet of love, and then uses that study to claim that viewing love from the perspective of the body will allow an individual to “train” this particular facet to experience a more wholesome life. For example, after thoroughly explaining the vagus nerve and how it may be exercised and strengthened as a muscle, Fredrickson cites a study she carried out in which, “... by random assignment, we determined which participants would learn loving-kindness meditation and which would not... through painstaking statistical analyses, we pinpointed that those who experienced the most frequent positivity resonance in connection with others showed the biggest increases in vagal tone” (Fredrickson 119-120). Through painstaking research, Fredrickson and her team discovered an astounding fact - individuals that experienced the most positive connections with others during the study were measured as experiencing the highest increases in love. When read in plain language, this discovery seems to be nonsensical and nothing more than common sense; however, by branding normal positive connections with others with terms such as “loving-kindness meditation” and “positivity resonance”, Fredrickson makes the reader believe that her new framework of love is revolutionary and unique. Fredrickson does not only do this via word choice, this same technique flows throughout her writing style. With just a cursory glance of the text, one may notice the high frequency of italicized words, or the highly romanticized section titles such as “Love on the Brain” (Fredrickson 110). With devices such as these, solely meant to capture the attention of readers, the legitimacy of the article comes into question - are the conclusions made in the article as factual as originally presented?

Italicized words and romanticized section titles are not the only culprits of illegitimacy within this article; there seems to be a common trend that Fredrickson follows within each of her sections. In the “Love on the Brain” section, Fredrickson uses four pages to describe the fMRI experiment carried out by Uri Hasson of Princeton University, and concludes from the experiment that “...neural synchrony and overlap can also unfold between you and a complete stranger...” (Fredrickson 114). This conclusion is followed by a miniscule quarter page summary of an experiment in Taiwan, upon which Fredrickson draws further conclusions. Disregarding the fact that her takeaway from the experiment is extremely oversimplified and completely overlooks the social reality of strangers not interacting with one another, this same pattern may be observed in the next section of the article, “Biochemistries in Love.” Fredrickson begins with two page explanation of a Swiss oxytocin experiment carried out in Zurich followed by a one page conclusion from the experiment. Then, with almost no detail whatsoever, Fredrickson briefly mentions an experiment carried out by researchers over infant-parent pairs in two sentences, which she then uses to form even larger conclusions. In both of these sections, Fredrickson begins by forming an at least partially sound conclusion based on well presented research, and then sneaks in an extremely concise explanation of a second experiment which she utilizes to romanticize the claim that she originally made. This can be seen after her brief summary of the infant-parent pair experiment, where she claims, “Positivity resonance, then, can be viewed as the doorway through which the exquisitely attuned biochemical tendencies of one generation influence those of the next generation to form lasting, often lifelong bonds” (Fredrickson 117). Fredrickson utilizes novel phrasing and word choice to explain to the reader that babies and their parents form lifelong bonds through love. When reading such sentences, it

becomes difficult to discern whether the article is written by a Ph. D presenting a claim through research or an online blog post made to attract the reader into buying the entire novel.

Fredrickson does not just utilize small, last-minute explanations of experiments to form romanticized conclusions, she also uses them in attempts to curb larger questions that have the possibility of debunking her new framework for love. In said framework, Fredrickson tells the reader to look at love as a biological system; a biological system pertains to independent or interrelated objects comprising and functioning as a whole. Fredrickson presents research regarding the independent objects, but fails to address how these objects compromise and function as a whole. For example, in one section Fredrickson describes to the reader how “under the influence of oxytocin, you attend more to people’s eyes and specifically more attuned to their smiles... you become a better judge of their feelings and view people on the whole as more attractive and trustworthy” (Fredrickson 115). Prior to this claim, Fredrickson provided a solid amount of research to back up her first statement - it is true that higher oxytocin levels makes an individual more attuned to the body language of others. What she did not explain, however, was how understanding the body language of others somehow makes them seem more attractive and trustworthy. Going even further, even if her claim is correct and being attuned to the body language of others makes them appear more attractive and trustworthy, the dynamic of wanting to be around said individuals more is poorly explained. In an effort to answer this lingering question, Fredrickson once again utilizes a conveniently placed quarter-page summary of an experiment that involves rats to support her claim. Coupled with her usage of italics and romanticized phrases, this may appear to make perfect sense to the reader; however, the reality of the situation is that it is a save-face for a gaping hole in her theory.

Since ancient times, society has viewed love as a centerpiece for change - a plethora of dated epics and tales revolve around a hero finding love, losing it, and stopping at no lengths to get it back. In *The Iliad*, written somewhere between 710 - 760 BC by Greek poet Homer, a ten-year war is waged by the Achaeans in the city of Troy after Paris of Troy takes Helen from the king of Sparta. This trope has only exacerbated as time has gone on - in 1597 *Romeo and Juliet* was published by William Shakespeare, in which Juliet falls in love with a young man named Romeo from the opposing House in their town. In a hectic series of events, Romeo gets exiled, and Juliet goes as far as to fake her own death in an attempt to be with him once more. No matter what form it takes - as a significant other, hobby, or thirst for power - love is the primary motivator for endless forms of art, and furthermore, connection. Viewing love from the perspective of the body may help the reader better understand what oxytocin does in the body, or how the vagus nerve affects communication with others, but completely overlooks and fails to explain the deeper workings and powers of love. Scientific models are extremely useful tools that can be utilized to predict a wide variety of phenomena - hurricanes, earthquakes, and even planetary motion are just a few examples. Some things, however, are simply not meant to be predicted. If love were a conquerable science that everyone could master, it would cease to exist, and a world without love is a world without change or progress - essentially, science may be a form of love, but love is most definitely not a science.